



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

P.T. Usha: Grassroots development holds the key to India's future success

P.T. Usha, the first woman president of the Indian Olympic Association and one of India's greatest athletes, called for a cultural shift in how the country views sport, saying grassroots development holds the key to India's future success. Usha began by congratulating the organisers of the of PlayCom 2025: Business of Sports Summit. "Sportstar has been an iconic magazine for decades, one I have admired and had the honour of featuring in multiple times. KPMG too deserves appreciation for developing a mobile application for athletes who travelled to the Paris Olympics in 2024, a thoughtful innovation that was very well received."

Usha said her defining moment came at the 1984 Los Angeles Olympics, where she missed the 400m hurdles bronze medal by a hundredth of a second. "To many, it looked like defeat. But for me, it was a defining moment. It proved that an Indian woman could stand shoulder to shoulder with the best in the world."

"Dhyan Chand's hockey is our dream, Milkha Singh's inspirational runs, cricketers uniting the nation, and today's champions in badminton, wrestling, boxing, and shooting —

these triumphs are not just medals or records, they are turning points that changed how India saw itself and what it believed was possible. But history alone cannot carry us forward. The real question is, what is the future of Indian sports? I believe the answer lies in grassroots development."

Usha pressed for a change in mindset across society. "Sports should not be something we watch only during a big match. It should be woven into our daily lives. Every school should give children time and space to play. Every community should have safe grounds for boys and girls to train. Parents should see sport not as a risk, but as an opportunity. When we build such a culture, medals and records will follow naturally," she said.

